



**Set the ball rolling:** Punjab Sports Minister Gurmeet Singh Meet Hayer delivered the keynote address at the Sportstar Sports Conclave, 'Focus Punjab, held in Chandigarh. R. V. MOORTHY

## Ushering in a new era of sports

**T**he first-ever 'Focus Punjab' Sportstar Sports Conclave, which took place in Chandigarh, addressed issues in various sporting disciplines and discussed ways to improve playing conditions.

Punjab Sports Minister Gurmeet Singh Meet Hayer laid out the steps taken by the state to ameliorate its presence in the sporting landscape of the country. "For a very long time, we contributed immensely to the country's sporting achievements and were number one among the states. This Asian Games performance is an indication that Punjab is heading back to the top," Meet Hayer said.

Meet Hayer shed light on the State's sports policy and its priorities. "Punjab introduced a sports policy recently, and I can guarantee that no other state has one

like this. We conducted meetings over the last six months with federations and associations across the sporting spectrum to come up with this policy," he said. "We focused on three broad aspects. If a player brings home an international medal at the Commonwealth Games, Asian Games, or other major competitions, we set aside a fund of 75 crores to honour them, secure their future, and give them a job."

Ranjit Bajaj, Director, Minerva Punjab FC, called for exposure trips at the age-group level. "We keep talking about friendlies, and tours; all those are for experienced athletes, to improve 0.0001%. If you give the same exposure to youth, their exposure is 20-30 per cent. Ninety per cent of all sports is in the mind. Unless your mind believes, no matter what you do, you cannot do it," Bajaj said in a panel on sports for skill-building

